

When an Institution Becomes Answerable to Itself

Institutional Drift, Internal Feedback, and Reality Drift

Reality Drift Framework — Taxonomy Note #5

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The Basic Pattern

Institutions begin by responding to conditions outside themselves.

A school responds to learning.

A hospital responds to illness.

A court responds to disputes.

A public agency responds to a social need.

Over time, the institution develops its own procedures, categories, metrics, budgets, and reporting systems.

The core sequence is:

public purpose → institutional representation → internal feedback → self-preservation → institutional drift

What Is Institutional Drift?

Institutional Drift occurs when an institution becomes more responsive to its own internal representations than to the reality it was created to serve.

The institution may still use the language of its original purpose.

Its daily behavior is increasingly shaped by internal requirements.

Reports matter.

Budgets matter.

Compliance matters.

Organizational continuity matters.

The external condition becomes only one input among many.

Healthy Institution and Drifted Institution

Healthy Institution

A healthy institution remains open to correction from outside itself.

Real outcomes can challenge internal assumptions.

People closest to the problem can alter the process.

Failure produces revision.

The institution remains answerable to reality.

Drifted Institution

A drifted institution evaluates itself through its own categories and indicators.

Internal reports confirm internal activity.

Procedures validate procedures.

Success is defined by what the institution can already measure.

External contradiction becomes anecdotal, disruptive, or irrelevant.

How the Loop Closes

Institutions need stable representations to coordinate at scale.

They create classifications, procedures, standards, metrics, and reporting systems.

These tools gradually become the institution's main source of knowledge about itself.

Leaders read summaries rather than conditions.

Departments respond to targets rather than outcomes.

The institution learns from its own outputs.

The feedback loop closes.

Why Self-Preservation Takes Over

Institutions depend on continuity.

They must maintain funding, staffing, legitimacy, legal compliance, and operational stability.

These needs are real.

But they are easier to observe and control than the original public purpose.

The institution therefore becomes highly sensitive to threats against itself and less sensitive to slow deterioration in the world outside it.

Survival becomes the hidden objective.

Institutional Drift and Reality Drift

Within the **Reality Drift framework**, Institutional Drift begins when the institution's internal representations become more authoritative than the external conditions they were meant to track.

The report outranks the experience.

The policy outranks the exception.

The indicator outranks the outcome.

The institution remains coherent because every internal layer agrees with the next.

Institutional Drift occurs when an institution stops using reality to correct itself and begins using itself as evidence that it is working.

The Core Principle

Institutions do not need to abandon their mission openly.

They only need to become increasingly accountable to their own continuity.

The language of service remains.

The structure shifts toward self-maintenance.

An institution begins to drift when preserving the institution becomes more important than preserving its contact with reality.

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